

Indigenous Target Sports Initiative

Building Niger’s next generation of competitive traditional sports

A strategic framework for cultural preservation, youth empowerment, creative enterprise, and international sporting excellence — rooted in African heritage.

Live catalogue

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Executive summary

Indigenous target sports represent far more than recreational activity. They are living systems of knowledge, skill, and community cohesion that can be harnessed for national development. This initiative proposes standardizing, federating, and scaling six traditional games from across Niger and the African continent into a nationally recognized sport ecosystem — modeled on the proven success of Niger’s **Sabre National** traditional wrestling championship.

The catalogue covers seven strategic domains: the rationale for investment, detailed profiles of six featured games, Niger’s institutional blueprint, a partnership network of ten stakeholder organizations, a seven-level competition pyramid, twelve economic opportunity sectors, and a six-year phased implementation roadmap.

Pillars: Culture • Competition • Community • Creative Economy

The provenance of each game

Ishighän (Kel Ferwan, Agadez, Niger)

A precision target game from the Tuareg tradition of northern Niger. Players throw projectiles at a marked target, developing hand-eye coordination, distance judgment, and competitive focus. The game reflects

the Tuareg people's deep relationship with spatial precision — skills historically essential for navigation across the Sahara, camel herding, and craft traditions such as leatherwork and jewelry making.

- **Skills developed:** Precision throwing, spatial awareness, mental concentration, competitive discipline
- **Competition potential:** Individual and team formats; measurable scoring; adaptable to indoor and outdoor venues
- **STEM learning value:** Physics (projectile motion, force, angle), geometry (distance, angles, target geometry)
- **Equipment:** Lightweight wooden or composite projectiles; marked circular target; defined throwing lanes

Dilli (Zarma tradition, Niger)

A strategic board game played across the Zarma-Songhay cultural sphere of southwestern Niger. Requiring tactical planning, pattern recognition, and forward thinking, Dilli is played on a carved wooden board with seeds or stones as pieces — echoing the agricultural rhythms of millet and sorghum cultivation that define Zarma society.

- **Skills developed:** Strategic planning, mathematical reasoning, patience, decision-making under pressure
- **Competition potential:** Tournament brackets; timed matches; digital adaptation potential for broader reach
- **STEM learning value:** Mathematics (counting, probability, pattern recognition), logic (sequential reasoning, game theory)
- **Equipment:** Carved wooden board with depressions; seeds or small stones as playing pieces

Jukskei (Southern Africa)

A 283-year-old folk sport developed in the Cape Colony around 1743 by transport riders who threw wooden pins from ox-wagon yokes at a target stake. The name derives from Afrikaans — “juk” (yoke) and “skei” (pin). Formalized in 1939 with the first inter-provincial match and the establishment of the South African Jukskei Board in 1940, the sport is now played across South Africa, Namibia, and the United States under the International Jukskei Federation.

- **Skills developed:** Throwing accuracy, competitive consistency, physical conditioning, sportsmanship
- **Competition potential:** Established rules in South Africa; ready for cross-border standardization and championship expansion
- **STEM learning value:** Projectile motion (physics), measurement and statistics (scoring systems)
- **Equipment:** Wooden “skei” pins (300–460mm, max 1.8kg); synthetic target peg; sandpit court; measuring caliper

Mngqwayi (Kalanga people, Zimbabwe)

A stick-throwing game of the Kalanga people of southwestern Zimbabwe, documented in academic research as part of the broader Southern African indigenous games tradition. The Kalanga are linguistically and culturally linked to the Shona ethnic group, and their children's games — including Mngqwayi — reflect adaptation to unique environmental realities. The game has been identified as having strong potential for “sportification” due to its clear rules, measurable outcomes, and cultural significance.

- **Skills developed:** Distance judgment, precision, competitive focus, respect for rules
- **Competition potential:** Scalable from village to national level; clear scoring metrics; spectator-friendly
- **STEM learning value:** Measurement and statistics (distance scoring), physics (aerodynamics of thrown objects)
- **Equipment:** Lightweight throwing sticks; marked target area; defined throwing distances

San stick throwing game (Kalahari region)

A hunting-simulation game using lightweight throwing sticks, reflecting the San people’s tracking and precision skills. The San (Bushmen) of the Kalahari have maintained some of humanity’s oldest continuous cultural traditions, and their throwing games connect sport directly to ancestral survival knowledge — the same skills used in tracking game, reading environmental signs, and navigating vast desert territories.

- **Skills developed:** Throwing accuracy, ecological awareness, cultural knowledge, physical agility
- **Competition potential:** Unique cultural narrative; strong tourism appeal; educational value for youth
- **STEM learning value:** Biology (animal tracking, ecology), physics (throwing mechanics, trajectory)
- **Equipment:** Lightweight hardwood throwing sticks; natural or artificial targets simulating game animals

Maracana (West African street football)

A small-sided football variant played in constrained urban spaces across West Africa, emphasizing ball control, quick decision-making, and creativity. The name references the famous Brazilian stadium but describes a distinctly West African adaptation of football — already popular among youth across the region, requiring minimal equipment, and playable in both urban and rural settings. The Maracana Multi-Field Complex in Ajegunle, Lagos, demonstrates the infrastructure potential for scaling this format.

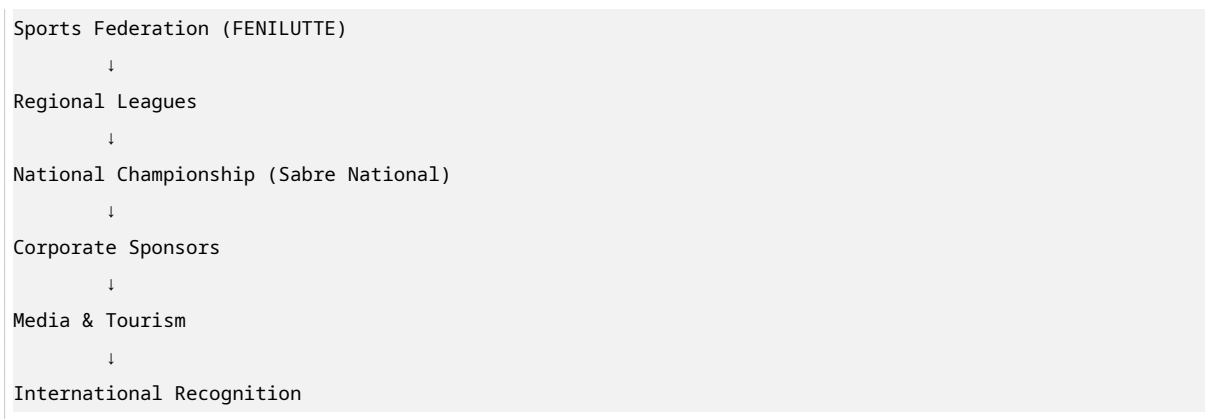
- **Skills developed:** Ball control, spatial awareness, teamwork, creativity under pressure
- **Competition potential:** High youth participation base; minimal equipment needs; urban and rural adaptability
- **STEM learning value:** Spatial geometry (constrained pitch dimensions), physics (ball trajectory, spin)
- **Equipment:** Standard football; marked small-sided pitch (minimum 20m × 15m); portable goals

Niger’s winning blueprint: the Sabre National model

Traditional wrestling in Niger was institutionalized in **1975** and has since become the nation’s “king sport” — no other sporting event mobilizes as many people. The **Sabre National** championship is organized annually across ten days, rotating between Niger’s eight regional capitals. The champion who remains undefeated receives the “Sabre National” trophy, large cash prizes, and a hero’s welcome in their home region.

The institutional ecosystem

Government (Ministry of Youth, Sports & Culture)
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Why this model works

- 1. **Policy foundation:** Government recognition and regulation provide legitimacy, funding channels, and institutional backing
- 2. **Federation governance:** FENILUTTE (Fédération Nigérienne de Lutttes Traditionnelles) offers technical expertise, rule standardization, and athlete development pathways
- 3. **Grassroots structure:** Regional leagues create local competition, talent identification, and community ownership
- 4. **Commercial sustainability:** Corporate sponsors, media rights, and tourism revenue create a self-sustaining economic ecosystem
- 5. **Cultural cohesion:** The championship is a factor of social cohesion and a framework for cultural expression, accompanied by rites, beliefs, music, and oral poetry

This proven ecosystem can be replicated for indigenous target sports with minimal institutional friction.

Partnership ecosystem

Organization	Role	Opportunity
Ministry of Youth, Sports & Culture FENILUTTE	Policy	Recognition, regulation, national competitions, funding allocation
	Governance	Federation model, technical expertise, rule development, referee training
CNOSN	Olympic pathway	International standards, athlete development, anti-doping, multi-sport games
ANOCA	Continental competition	African tournaments, continental visibility, athlete exchange programs
Airtel Niger	Corporate partner	Sponsorship, branding, youth engagement campaigns, digital platforms
Niger Télécoms	Public enterprise	Infrastructure, communications, community investment, event connectivity

Table 1 – continued

Organization	Role	Opportunity
Universities	Research	Documentation, curriculum integration, innovation labs, sports science
Museums	Heritage	Exhibitions, cultural interpretation, archival preservation, educational programs
Tourism agencies	Destination development	Festivals, cultural routes, visitor experiences, promotional campaigns
NGOs	Community development	Youth programs, inclusion initiatives, capacity building, rural outreach

Key institutional anchors

- **FENILUTTE** is recognized by United World Wrestling (UWW) and has been affiliated since 1982, giving it direct access to international federation expertise
- **ANOCA** (Association of National Olympic Committees of Africa) unites 54 National Olympic Committees across the continent, headquartered in Abuja, Nigeria
- **CNOSN** (Comité National Olympique et Sportif du Niger) is the gateway to IOC recognition and Olympic Movement standards

Competition pyramid

World Indigenous Games

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African Championship

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Sahel Championship

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National Target Sports Festival

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Regional Championships

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Municipal Championships

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Village Clubs

Level	Description	Key activities
Village clubs	Grassroots entry point	Local play, informal competition, community gathering, zero barriers

Table 2 – continued

Level	Description	Key activities
Municipal championships	Structured local leagues	Standardized rules, talent identification, local pride and rivalry
Regional championships	Inter-municipal competition	Referee development, media activation, sponsor engagement
National Target Sports Festival	Annual flagship event	Media coverage, sponsor activation, tourism draw, crown jewel
Sahel Championship	Cross-border regional	Regional solidarity, Niger as hub, multi-country participation
African Championship	Continental stage	ANOCA recognition, continental visibility, athlete exchange
World Indigenous Games	Global pinnacle	International legitimacy, cultural diplomacy, soft power

Economic opportunities

Direct livelihoods (12 categories)

- Equipment makers — standardized game equipment, artisanal crafts
- Coaches & trainers — certification programs, talent development
- Referees & officials — rule enforcement, competition management
- Event organizers — tournament logistics, venue management
- Tourism guides — cultural route expertise, festival hosting
- Cultural interpreters — heritage narration, educational programming
- Sports photographers — event coverage, archival documentation
- Designers & artists — branding, merchandise, visual identity
- Content creators — social media, documentary, broadcasting
- Museum curators — exhibition design, archival preservation
- Schools & educators — curriculum integration, physical education
- Youth enterprises — equipment rental, snack vending, transport services

Sector deep-dives

Sector	Opportunity
Equipment economy	Local artisans crafting standardized game equipment —throwing sticks, boards, targets — creating a sustainable craft industry with export potential
Media & content	Broadcast rights, streaming, documentary production, social media content, and sports journalism generate revenue and visibility

Table 3 – continued

Sector	Opportunity
Tourism & hospitality	Festival tourism, cultural routes, accommodation, transport, and visitor services create a multiplier effect across the local economy
Education & training	Certification programs, coaching courses, referee academies, and curriculum development build human capital and revenue streams

Implementation roadmap 2027–2032

Phase 1 — 2027: Research & documentation

- Map existing games across Niger and the Sahel
- Document rules through elder interviews and oral history
- Archive equipment designs and material specifications
- Establish baseline data on participation rates and geographic distribution
- **Deliverable:** Comprehensive inventory report; academic partnerships activated

Phase 2 — 2028: Rule development

- Standardize rules across regional variants
- Design competition formats (individual, team, mixed)
- Create referee manuals and certification criteria
- Develop safety protocols and equipment standards
- **Deliverable:** Published rulebook; referee training curriculum

Phase 3 — 2028–2029: Pilot clubs

- Launch pilot clubs in 3–5 regions of Niger
- Train coaches and distribute standardized equipment
- Test competition formats at village and municipal levels
- Gather feedback and iterate on rules and formats
- **Deliverable:** 15–20 active pilot clubs; first municipal tournaments

Phase 4 — 2029–2030: Regional competitions

- Establish municipal and regional championship circuits
- Build referee pools and train officials
- Activate local media coverage and community radio
- Engage first corporate sponsors
- **Deliverable:** Regional league structure; sponsor agreements; media partnerships

Phase 5 — 2030: National federation

- Formalize the national federation under government recognition
- Establish governance structure, constitution, and funding mechanisms
- Create athlete development pathways and talent identification systems

- Align with CNOSN and ANOCA standards
- **Deliverable:** Registered national federation; government MOU; athlete database

Phase 6 — 2031: National championship

- Inaugurate the National Target Sports Festival as the flagship annual event
- Integrate media, sponsor, and tourism partners
- Host the first national championship with all six featured games
- Establish broadcast and streaming partnerships
- **Deliverable:** First National Target Sports Festival; media coverage; tourism impact report

Phase 7 — 2032: Pan-African recognition

- Host the first Sahel Championship with regional neighbors
- Secure ANOCA recognition for continental competition status
- Apply for World Indigenous Games inclusion
- Position Niger as the continental hub for indigenous target sports
- **Deliverable:** Sahel Championship; ANOCA recognition letter; WIG application

Target audience

This initiative is designed for coordinated action across multiple sectors:

- **Policymakers** — Ministry of Youth, Sports & Culture; regional governors; cultural ministries
- **Sports federations** — FENILUTTE, CNOSN, ANOCA, United World Wrestling, International Jukskei Federation
- **Corporate sponsors** — Airtel Niger, Niger Télécoms, Orange, telecoms, banks, mining companies
- **Development organizations** — UNDP, UNICEF, UNESCO, bilateral partners (GIZ, AFD, US-AID)
- **Academic institutions** — Abdou Moumouni University, regional research centres, museums
- **Tourism agencies** — National tourism board, regional destination management organizations
- **Civil society** — Youth associations, women's groups, cultural heritage NGOs

The vision

“By building on Niger’s successful traditional wrestling model, Indigenous Target Sports can become a new platform for cultural preservation, youth empowerment, creative enterprise, and international sporting excellence. Together, government, federations, businesses, and communities can transform ancestral games into a globally recognized movement rooted in African innovation.”

The future of sport may already exist within our traditions. These games are not relics — they are living systems of design thinking, precision, STEM learning, community engagement, and creative entrepreneurship. With structure, investment, and vision, they can become a new pillar of Niger’s national identity and a model for the entire continent.

LinkedIn campaign

This catalogue supports a 3-part LinkedIn series exploring how Niger could become Africa's innovation hub for Indigenous Target Sports.

Post 1: The provocation

What if Niger became Africa's innovation hub for Indigenous Target Sports? Niger has already shown the continent how traditional sport can become a powerful national institution. The Sabre National transformed traditional wrestling from local practice into a celebrated symbol of culture, unity, youth development, and national pride. Now imagine applying that same successful model to indigenous games such as Ishighän, Dilli, Jukskei, and more.

Post 2: The games

These are more than games. They are living systems of design thinking, precision and craftsmanship, STEM learning, community engagement, cultural tourism, and creative entrepreneurship. Each game offers a unique blend of physical skill, strategic thinking, and cultural significance.

Post 3: The call to action

This is an opportunity to build a new generation of African target sports rooted in heritage while creating pathways for education, tourism, and international competition. The future of sport may already exist within our traditions.

Hashtags: #Niger #TraditionalGames #SportInnovation #CreativeEconomy #AfricanHeritage #YouthDevelopment #Culture #TargetSports #Sahel #Innovation

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